

A Key to Comfort

The market as of now is full of choices as far as keyboards are concerned. You can find a cheap, no-frills keyboard that is sturdy and does the job at a rock bottom price of Rs 300. At the other end of the spectrum, you can also find a feature-rich keyboard loaded with shortcut keys and USB ports built in, which could cost you up to Rs 3,500.

Samsung offers some of the sturdiest keyboards, though Acer keyboards are also a good choice if you are looking for a value solution. If you want good looks along with a reasonable choice of features then you could go in for keyboards from Maple or Logitech.

There are several types to choose from, including the normal 104-button PS/2 keyboards and the newer cordless models that use radio waves or infrared rays to communicate.

TECHNOLOGY INSIGHT
Layout

The QWERTY layout is the most popular one in business, but some people prefer the ergonomic models. The Natural and split keyboards from Microsoft are examples of these.

SMART TIPS
Keyboard construction: This can be critical in terms of reducing the chance of stress-related injuries. The choices available include mechanical keyboards, which are more responsive but tend to be noisier and membrane keyboards, which are quieter and more comfortable to type with.

Connectors: Most keyboards have switched to the PS/2 connector format, but if you have an older PC you might have a port which requires an old AT style

connector. If you have a free USB port you could consider a more expensive USB compatible model.



	General use	Heavy user	Neat and tidy
You need	To do small amounts of typing and use your machine primarily for the Internet	To do large volumes of typing tasks and you are a heavy user of the keyboard	A neat keyboard. You just can't stand the mess caused by a tangle of cables
Look for	A standard 104-key keyboard preferably with configurable shortcut keys.	An ergonomically designed keyboard to avoid stress-related injuries	Infrared or radio frequency based cordless keyboards
Our pick	Samsung SDL1500	Microsoft Natural Keyboard	Logitech Cordless Freedom Navigator
Price range	Up to Rs 500	Up to Rs 3,000	Up to Rs 5,000



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Also Remember...

- Learning to type on any of the ergonomic keyboards can take a while and may not be worth the effort unless you do a lot of typing.
- Not all keyboards come with a palmrest but this provides the user with some comfort while typing for prolonged periods. They are now available even with some of the lowest priced models.
- While shortcut keys (custom keys) can be useful for everyone, they are especially useful for those who don't have a clue about the regular Windows and Internet shortcut key combinations.